

Reason to Create

Reason from Propellorhead Software can without any doubt be termed as fully loaded. This software basically is a software emulation of an electronic music project studio. The software has a mind-blowing interface and you will be amazed with its features. The interface is as intu-



Front view of Reason

itive as it can get and the wildest feature about the software probably is that you can literally turn the software around. You can actually see the front and the back of the software by just pressing the tab button, and play around with the wires by actually plugging it out or into any port.



Back view of Reason

There are lots of modules such as Digital Sampler, Dr Rex Loop Player, Redrum Drum Computer, Digital Reverb, and Digital Delay Line. All of these offer great effects and help you make great music. But the interesting one of the lot is the Matrix Pattern Sequencer. Through this you can easily program group note triggers, which are repeated. Apart from this there are eight effects processors.

Another neat feature in this software is that you can rename the modules to anything you want. Reason includes a built-in, and extremely intuitive graphical MIDI sequencer, which is capable of recording and editing any real time knob or fader changes you make as your song plays, and these changes can be recorded in real time as your sequence plays. The demo can be downloaded from the official site, www.propellorheads.se.



Drag and drop files with Cubase VST 5

are packed with features normally found only in high-end packages. Take Cakewalk Pro Audio 9 for instance. It supports audio up to 255 tracks and there are two new plugins included in this version, namely Style Enhancer and Sessions Drummer. These are two tidy features that allow the rhythm section (percussions) in the track to sound more natural and not canned. In Cakewalk Pro, styles such as shuffling tempos can automatically be incorporated into the track. Another feature is AudioX that allows soundcard manufacturers to write software so as to make their cards' features available within the sequencer.

Cubase VST 5 is another high-end audio and MIDI editor for professionals wanting to do some quality work. Besides the usual tools, you have the graphic equaliser. It supports 32-bit recording, and frequencies up to 96 KHz, which is equivalent to DAT quality.

Evolution has a Score Edit screen that allows you to view your MIDI information in standard musical notation and this can be edited and printed. Apart from this, there is a drum editor and a piano editor included. This software acts as your MIDI sequencer, thereby allowing you to control any MIDI musical device that's being connected to the PC, be it a soundcard or any external musical instrument. The included SMPTE/MTC support allows for synchronising this software with other external devices and sees to it that they are all running on the same clock and in time. The software even allows you to run a video for a Windows file and synchronise it with your music—ideal for creating soundtracks for video films.

MIDI Maestro 1.9 is yet another application that provides you with good features such as monophonic MIDI to audio transcription tool. It has support for DirectShow-compatible MIDI filters and other visual enhancements, such as the Staff View tool, using which you can draw musical notations and take printouts of it for future reference.

Ease of use

Apart from the new features, the new version of Cakewalk Pro has a better-looking interface and effects that can be applied in real-time as you are playing the file. It's possible to edit several MIDI files simultaneously in the Piano Roll Editor, and that

simplifies matters quite a bit as the Piano Roll easily allows you to create a song by simply dragging and dropping notes onto the view. Even when you open up a song, the different sounds are colour-coded, making it easier to edit. There are other views that Cakewalk allows, such as the Staff View (for people who can read and work with Sheet music). This makes it possible for a wide range of users to use this software—from the novice to the professional.

Cubase too allows you to drag and drop files in the interface and this makes editing MIDI sequences very easy. You can also simultaneously work with 128 channels of audio. But if you are using Cubase for the first time, you might find it a tad difficult to configure the VST plugins and other audio effects. Editing in MIDI Maestro is simple because of the easy-to-use drag and drop object style interface. Using this, you can easily change common track properties such as volume, balance, key, velocity offset and timing offsets of individual notes or groups of notes.

Performance

Cakewalk Pro carries enhancements such as the Wavepipe technology that reduces the latency or response time of the program. Compared to the previous version of this software, the time taken for a control to respond to a parameter change when mixing a large arrangement can be reduced to around one-tenth of a second